Response to Reviewers, Round 2

Inferring circadian phases and quantifying biological desynchrony across single-cell transcriptomes

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September 2026

We thank both reviewers for their second round of comments. Below we reproduce each comment (in *italics*) followed by our response.

A note on numbering. Figure, panel and equation references in our responses are to the revised manuscript unless stated otherwise. References of the form Fig. Reb N point to figures of this document, except in the reviewers' quoted comments, where we have added "[round 1]" to the ones that refer to the first round response.

Summary of main changes.

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Reviewer 1

R1.1 — Phase at which the Twin-Dataset is constructed

The phase at which the Twin-Dataset is constructed is never stated. The Methods define the twin as a synthetic dataset reproducing the per-cell library sizes and sequencing depth of the data under study, in which every cell shares the same circadian phase, and Eq. (15) then subtracts the resulting $\sigma_{technical}$ at "the group's sequencing depth". Which phase the cells are placed at is not specified anywhere. This is not a detail: the paper itself shows $\sigma_{technical}$ varying roughly two-fold around the cycle (Fig. S1F), so the choice materially determines every reported σ_{bio}. The response to my earlier point makes clear that the twin sits at the phase of the group it mirrors, and that this is precisely what protects the estimator from the phase-dependence concern I raised — but a reader of the manuscript alone cannot reconstruct the central estimator. One sentence in the Twin-Dataset paragraph would close this.

Response.

We thank the reviewer. The Twin-Dataset paragraph in the Methods now states that each twin is placed at the phase of the group it mirrors: the external time (ZT) for the mammalian and *Drosophila* data, and the circular mean of the inferred phases for the SABER-FISH time series.

R1.2 — Derivation of the period spread

Two problems in the derivation of the period spread. The Methods state that fixed period heterogeneity and within-cycle stochastic phase fluctuations "both produce a linearly growing cSTD, so they cannot be separated from a slope alone". Diffusive phase accumulation gives a variance linear in time and therefore a cSTD growing as the square root of time, whereas period heterogeneity gives a cSTD linear in time; the two have different time dependence. The two references cited in that same sentence treat the contributions as distinguishable in principle. Please clarify.

Response.

We thank the reviewer, the sentence was wrong. The Methods now state that period differences give a cSTD growing linearly in time and diffusive phase fluctuations one growing as the square root of time, and that with our eleven time points we cannot reliably separate the two. σ_T remains an upper bound.

R1.3 — Explanation of the phase dependence of $\sigma_{\text{technical}}$

The explanation offered for the phase-dependence of $\sigma_{technical}$ does not match the periodicity reported. The Results attribute the variation of $\sigma_{technical}$ across the cycle to "the non-uniform distribution of peak phases across the rhythmic gene set", which is a once-per-cycle effect. Yet the SABER-FISH paragraph describes the modulation recovered in real data as 12h-periodic, and Fig. S1F shows two maxima per cycle. The dominant mechanism — that a small phase error perturbs predicted expression in proportion to the local steepness of the cosine, which is flat at peak and at trough and steepest between them, giving two maxima per cycle — is stated clearly in a footnote of the response and appears nowhere in the manuscript. Uneven peak phases account only for the weaker once-per-cycle component. Please move the correct explanation into the Results; it is two sentences, and it matters because this modulation is what makes the per-time-point σ_{bio} values uneven, which the same paragraph goes on to discuss.

Response.

We thank the reviewer for catching this. The explanation in the Results was wrong. We have replaced it with the cosine steepness argument, which gives two maxima per cycle, and kept the uneven peak phases only as a weaker once per cycle component.

R1.4 — Supplementary tables and reproducibility

Supplementary tables and reproducibility. Tables S1, S2 and S3 are cited in the main text — the Extended-Set gene parameters, the per-cell-type and per-time-point variance components, and the Drosophila-Set parameters respectively — but are not present in the supplementary file supplied to me. Please confirm they ship with the paper rather than only with the code repository; Table S2 in particular is the item I wanted to see and is the one a reader will want alongside Fig. 3J. On the code itself, the position is now satisfactory in substance: both repositories are public and the preprocessed data are deposited. I can think of one potentially useful addition, which is the lightweight cell bootstrap that the authors describe as running in seconds from the deposited per-cell phases. I think this would be a very useful artefact in the repository if shipped as a standalone script.

Response.

Supplementary tables.

Tables S1, S2 and S3 are Excel files and were uploaded as separate supplementary data files with the submission, not inside the supplementary PDF. We apologise for the confusion and will

make sure they are provided again with the revised version.

STANDALONE BOOTSTRAP.

We agree and have added it as a tutorial notebook to the scRITMO repository (`tutorials/tutorial_sigma_bio_bootstrap.ipynb`), with the deposited per cell phases and technical values of the SABER-FISH series. It resamples the cells of each time point with replacement and recomputes σ_{data} and $\sigma_{\text{bio}} = \sqrt{\sigma^2_{\text{data}} - \sigma^2_{\text{tech}}}$, with σ_{tech} held fixed at its value from the twin dataset, so the error comes from the sampling of cells only. The slope, the late minus early contrast and σ_T are recomputed on every resample. It needs no GPU and runs in seconds.

Reviewer 2

R2.1

In response to my previous comment on the validity of their variance decomposition (R2.2 in the author's response), the authors argue that the conditioning variable S in their Equation 13 (revised main text) is one replicate at one ZT time point and that the $\sigma_{bio}/\sigma_{tech}$ split is a "further decomposition that lives entirely inside the within term". While this is OK, the author's decomposition purely within a ZT still must obey the law of total variance, since it is an identity that holds for any conditioning variable. Therefore, if Eq. 14 is to be more than an analogy, it must itself be a total-variance decomposition within one single ZT timepoint with respect to some conditioning variable, and the authors need to precisely define what that variable is. Otherwise, Eq. 14 appears quite ad hoc and it is impossible to interpret what the terms σ_{bio} and σ_{tech} are supposed to represent in a statistically rigorous framework.

Response. We thank the reviewer. The reviewer is right: a split of the variance inside one ZT has to follow the law of total variance (LTV), so we must say which variable we condition on. Writing this out showed us where Eq. 14 of the main text is exact and where it is only approximate, and it led us to a new estimator, the grid method, that avoids these approximations.

The conditioning variable is the true phase θ of the cell.

In short: the conditioning variable is the latent true phase θ of a cell in one replicate at one ZT. σ^2_{bio} is the variance of θ across those cells, and σ^2_{tech} is the average, over those cells, of the variance of the inferred phase at fixed θ. In the reviewer's terms, S (one replicate at one ZT) is the outer split, and θ is the variable inside the within S term, which is the further decomposition we referred to.

In detail, take one group b of n_b cells (one replicate at one ZT). Each cell is generated in two steps. Its true phase is drawn, $\theta \sim p_b(\theta)$, with mean μ_b and standard deviation $\sigma_{\text{bio},b}$. This spread of θ is the biological variability, and θ is never observed. Then the inferred phase of the cell is drawn, $\hat{\theta} \sim p(\hat{\theta} \mid \theta)$. The distribution $p(\hat{\theta} \mid \theta)$ comes from the count noise and from the inference, and it is the technical variability. Write $m(\theta) = \mathbb{E}[\hat{\theta} \mid \theta]$, $\varepsilon(\theta) = m(\theta) - \theta$ for the bias of the estimator, and $f(\theta) = \text{Var}(\hat{\theta} \mid \theta)$. The LTV with θ as the conditioning variable is

$$\underbrace{\text{Var}(\hat{\theta})}_{V_b} = \underbrace{\mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim p_b}\big[\,\text{Var}(\hat{\theta} \mid \theta)\big]}_{T_b\ \text{(technical)}} + \underbrace{\text{Var}_{\theta\sim p_b}\big(\mathbb{E}[\hat{\theta} \mid \theta]\big)}_{B_b\ \text{(biological)}}, \tag{1}$$

so $T_b = \int p_b(\theta)\, f(\theta)\, d\theta$ and $B_b = \text{Var}_{\theta\sim p_b}\big(m(\theta)\big)$. This holds for every group and every shape of p_b. If the estimator has no bias, $m(\theta) = \theta$, then $B_b = \sigma^2_{\text{bio},b}$. In practice the bias is not zero (for sparse cells, estimates are pulled toward the trough of the aggregate circadian counts, about ZT21), so $B_b \neq \sigma^2_{\text{bio},b}$ in general, and this matters for A2 below. The outer average runs over the cells of one group only, so the outer average does not cover the whole cycle. Averaging across groups is a separate step, treated in R2.3.

The circular form.

Phase wraps around at 24 h, so from here on we work on the circle. The variance of a group is $V_b = -2\ln \bar{R}_b$, where $\bar{R}_b$ is the length of the mean of the unit vectors $e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{\theta}}$ over the n_b cells, and $f(\theta) = -2\ln r(\theta)$ (defined below). Define $\rho(\theta) = \mathbb{E}[e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{\theta}} \mid \theta] = r(\theta)\, e^{\mathrm{i}m(\theta)}$, so that $m(\theta)$ is now the

mean direction. Conditioning on θ gives the exact identity

$$\mathbb{E}\big[e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{\theta}}\big] = \mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim p_b}\big[\rho(\theta)\big]. \tag{2}$$

If $r(\theta) = r$ is constant over the group and $m(\theta) = \theta$, the length of the right side is r times the length of $\mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim p_b}[e^{\mathrm{i}\theta}]$. Taking $-2\ln$ then gives $V_b = f + \sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$, with $f = -2\ln r$ and $\sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b} = -2\ln|\mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim p_b}e^{\mathrm{i}\theta}|$ the circular variance of θ. This is Eq. 14 of the main text, and it is exact under these two conditions.

Where the subtraction method is approximate.

The observed V_b is known, while T_b and B_b are not. The subtraction method (Eq. 14 of the main text, the method of the paper) estimates the two terms of Eq. (1) as follows. For the biological term the subtraction method takes $B_b \approx \sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$, which is exact if $m(\theta) = \theta$. For the technical term the subtraction method simulates a Twin dataset: a copy of the group in which all cells have the same true phase (no biological spread), the genome wide library size (UMI count per cell) of the group, and the fitted model. The variance of the inferred phases of the Twin dataset is f at that one phase. So $V_b \approx f(\mu_b) + \sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$. This is Eq. (1) with two approximations: (A1) T_b is evaluated at a single phase instead of averaged over p_b; (A2) the bias is neglected in B_b. For a small bias and a narrow p_b, the error $\Delta_b = V_b - \big(f(\mu_b) + \sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}\big)$ has one part for each approximation.

- **A1**, technical variance evaluated at one phase. The cells of the group lie at different true phases, and the technical variance f changes with the phase. The exact technical term is the average of f over these phases, while the subtraction method evaluates f at μ_b only. The estimate of $\sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$ is the data variance minus the Twin variance. Where f curves upward around μ_b, the average of f over the group is larger than the value at μ_b, so the Twin variance is too small and the estimate of σ_{bio} too large. Where f curves downward, the Twin variance is too large and the estimate of σ_{bio} too small. The error grows with $\sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$ and with how strongly f curves along the phase. Because phases are averaged as unit vectors on the circle, the circular form of the variance adds a smaller term to Δ_b, which is never positive.

- **A2**, bias left out of the biological term. Inferred phases are pulled toward the trough of the aggregate circadian counts (about ZT21). If the pull changes across the phases of the group, the inferred phases are squeezed together or spread apart compared with the true ones, and B_b is smaller or larger than $\sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$. Cells on both sides of the trough move toward it and end up closer together, so near the trough the estimate of σ_{bio} is too small. This error also grows with $\sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$.

So Eq. 14 of the main text is approximate within one ZT, and A1 and A2 are the reasons. Averaging over groups (Eq. 16 of the main text) can cancel part of Δ_b. We come back to this in the paragraph on the average over groups.

The new estimator: the grid method.

Instead of correcting these terms one by one, we start from Eq. (2) itself, which is exact. The left side of Eq. (2) comes from the data: the mean $\bar{z}_b$ of the unit vectors $e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{\theta}_c}$ of the cells, with $\bar{R}_b = |\bar{z}_b|$. On the right, $\rho(\theta)$ is the technical part and p_b is the biological part. We call it the grid method because we measure ρ with Twin cells on a grid of 24 phases, write it as a Fourier series, and average it over a wrapped normal p_b of width σ. Averaging gives the expected $\bar{R}_b^2$ of a group as a known function of σ, and $\hat{\sigma}_{\mathrm{bio},b}$ is the value of σ that matches the data. A1 and A2 disappear, because ρ is averaged over the whole of p_b, the direction of ρ holds the bias, and no variances are added. Appendix A gives the steps, what the grid method removes and the assumptions that remain.

The grid method in simulation.

We simulated 15 clock genes and 6 groups of 1000 cells at phases 4 h apart, at 3k, 10k and 30k UMI per cell, with a true spread of zero (all cells of a group at the same phase), 1.0 h or about 2.5 h (von Mises), and 5 replicates of the whole experiment. The data are generated from a perturbed copy of the fitted gene profiles, so the fitted model is not the generating model. The truth of a group is the circular standard deviation of the true phases of its cells. Fig. Reb 1A shows the absolute error of each group for the subtraction method and the grid method. Fig. Reb 1B compares the mean error of a single group with the mean error of the single value over the 6 groups of one replicate (Eq. 16 of the main text), $\sqrt{\sum_b n_b \hat{\sigma}^2_{\mathrm{bio},b} / \sum_b n_b}$, whose truth is the same average taken over the true values. When the data variance of a group falls below the technical variance, the estimate of that group is counted as zero for both methods, in both panels.

For a single group the grid method is more accurate. With a true spread of about 2.5 h, the grid method has a mean absolute error of 0.46 h against 0.60 h for the subtraction method at 3k, 0.17 against 0.24 h at 10k, and 0.07 against 0.15 h at 30k. With a spread of 1.0 h the difference is smaller (0.51 against 0.62 h, 0.26 against 0.28 h, and 0.14 against 0.16 h). For both methods the error falls as the depth goes up.

The single value over the 6 groups has a mean error 1.6 to 6 times smaller than the mean error of a single group (Fig. Reb 1B). At 10k and 30k the mean error is 0.08 h or less for both methods and both spreads, and the two methods give the same result. At 3k the grid method has the smaller error (0.24 against 0.35 h for a spread of 2.5 h, and 0.26 against 0.39 h for 1.0 h).

The figure does not show the case with no spread. In that case 43 to 67% of the groups, depending on depth and method, have a data variance below the technical variance and get an estimate of zero, and the others get a small positive value. Because the estimate of every group is at least zero, the single value over the groups cannot go below zero, and its mean error is about 0.4 h at 10k and 30k for both methods (0.7 to 0.8 h at 3k). At these depths an estimate of σ_{bio} below about 0.4 h cannot be told apart from zero. The same control (true σ_{bio} of 0) is repeated in the RNA-seq style simulation of R2.3c, with 12 time points (Fig. Reb 4B).

The oracle of R2.3c is a reference, not an estimator: it re-simulates each group at the true phases of its cells with the fitted model, so it has no A1 or A2 error.

The average over groups.

The decomposition is defined and estimated for each group b (one replicate at one ZT). The single value over groups, Eq. 16 of the main text, $\sqrt{\sum_b n_b \hat{\sigma}^2_{\mathrm{bio},b} / \sum_b n_b}$, is an extra step and not part of the definition. The single value estimates a σ_{bio} only if all groups share the same σ_{bio}. This is not the case in the SABER-FISH experiment, where σ_{bio} rises with time, so there we do not use the single value and we use the estimates per time point (R2.3c). When σ_{bio} changes across groups, the single value is the average of the group values weighted by the number of cells, and this average hides the change (R2.3c). Our first round statement that σ_{bio} is "a property of a population sampled across the cycle, not of an individual ZT" was too strong.

A single group already gives a usable estimate from about 10k UMI per cell (Fig. Reb 1A). When σ_{bio} is the same in all groups around the clock, the average reduces the error on σ_{bio}, by a factor of 1.6 to 6 in the simulation above (Fig. Reb 1B).

Part of this gain comes from averaging the noise of single groups. The rest comes from the cancellation of the subtraction error Δ_b. With evenly spaced time points and the same $\sigma_{\mathrm{bio},b}$, depth and number of cells in every group, the main parts of A1 (f taken at one phase) and A2 (bias left out) change sign around the cycle (f curves upward at some phases and downward at others, and the cells are squeezed at some phases and spread apart at others), so they cancel in the average

over groups. The cancellation removes every daily rhythm of f and of the bias except those with a period of $24/N$ h or a whole fraction of it, where N is the number of time points. With 6 time points 4 h apart, only rhythms with a period of 4 h, 2 h and shorter remain, and these rhythms are small.

The other parts do not cancel: the circle term of A1 (the term that comes from averaging unit vectors) keeps one sign, and so does a smaller part of A2 that grows with the square of the squeezing. So a small error is left, and this error is included in the error of the single value in the simulation above. With few time points the cancellation is weaker (R2.4).

When all groups share one σ_{bio}, there is also a more direct way to combine them than averaging the estimates. The equation of each group follows from the law of total expectation, and so does the sum of these equations over groups. We solve this sum numerically for a single σ_{bio} (Appendix A).

Which estimator the paper uses.

The decomposition is the same for both methods, namely Eq. (1) with θ as the conditioning variable. The two methods differ only in how they estimate the technical part. The subtraction method evaluates the technical part at one phase. The grid method averages the technical part over p_b and keeps the bias in the direction of ρ.

In simulation, from 10k UMI per cell upward, the two methods agree on the single value. Its error is 0.08 h or less for both methods, and the slopes over time points lead to the same conclusion (R2.3c).

On the real data the two methods also agree (Fig. Reb 2). For the mouse cell types of Fig. 3J of the main text the single values differ by 0.02 h or less, except for the Lyve1+ macrophages (3.79 against 3.88 h). For the *Drosophila* clusters of Fig. 4F of the main text the grid method is 0.03 to 0.28 h higher, and for both methods σ_{bio} is higher in DD than in LD in the same 3 of 4 clusters. On SABER-FISH the spread of periods from the slope over time is 1.04 h with the grid method against 1.37 h with the subtraction method.

Both methods use the same fitted model and the same simulated cells. So the agreement of the two methods shows that the approximations of the subtraction method do not drive these results.

The agreement does not test the fit itself, which is the larger source of error (R2.3c). We therefore keep the subtraction method as the main estimator, so the results that both reviewers checked in the first round do not change.

The grid method is better at low depth. At 3k and a spread of 2.5 h, the error is 0.46 against 0.60 h for a single group and 0.24 against 0.35 h for the single value.

We recommend the grid method at low depth. The grid method is an option in the scRitmo package: `model.desynchrony(..., method="deconvolution", deconv_form="vector")`. The default, `method="simulation"`, is the subtraction method.

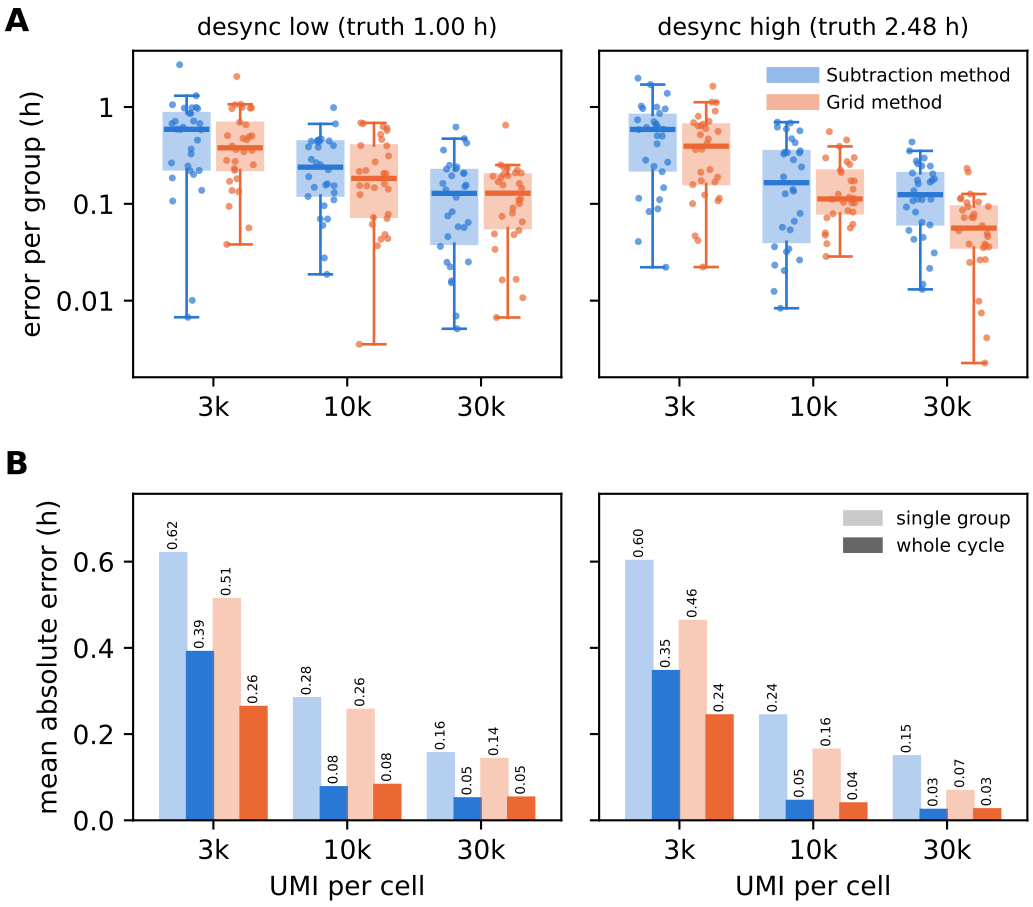


Figure Reb 1: **Absolute error of $\hat{\sigma}_{\text{bio}}$ in simulation, subtraction method and grid method.** 15 clock genes, 6 groups of 1000 cells at phases 4 h apart, 5 replicates of the experiment. Columns: low and high desynchrony, with the mean true spread in the panel titles. The x axis is the number of UMI per cell. A group whose estimate falls below the technical value is counted as zero for both methods. **(A)** Error of each group: absolute value of the estimate minus the circular standard deviation of the true phases of the cells of the group, log scale. Boxes: median and quartiles, whiskers to 1.5 times the interquartile range, 30 groups per box. Dots: single groups. **(B)** Mean absolute error of a single group (light bars, 30 groups) and of the single value over the 6 groups of one replicate (dark bars, Eq. 16 of the main text, 5 replicates), for the subtraction method (blue) and the grid method (orange). The truth of the single value is the same average taken over the true values of the groups.

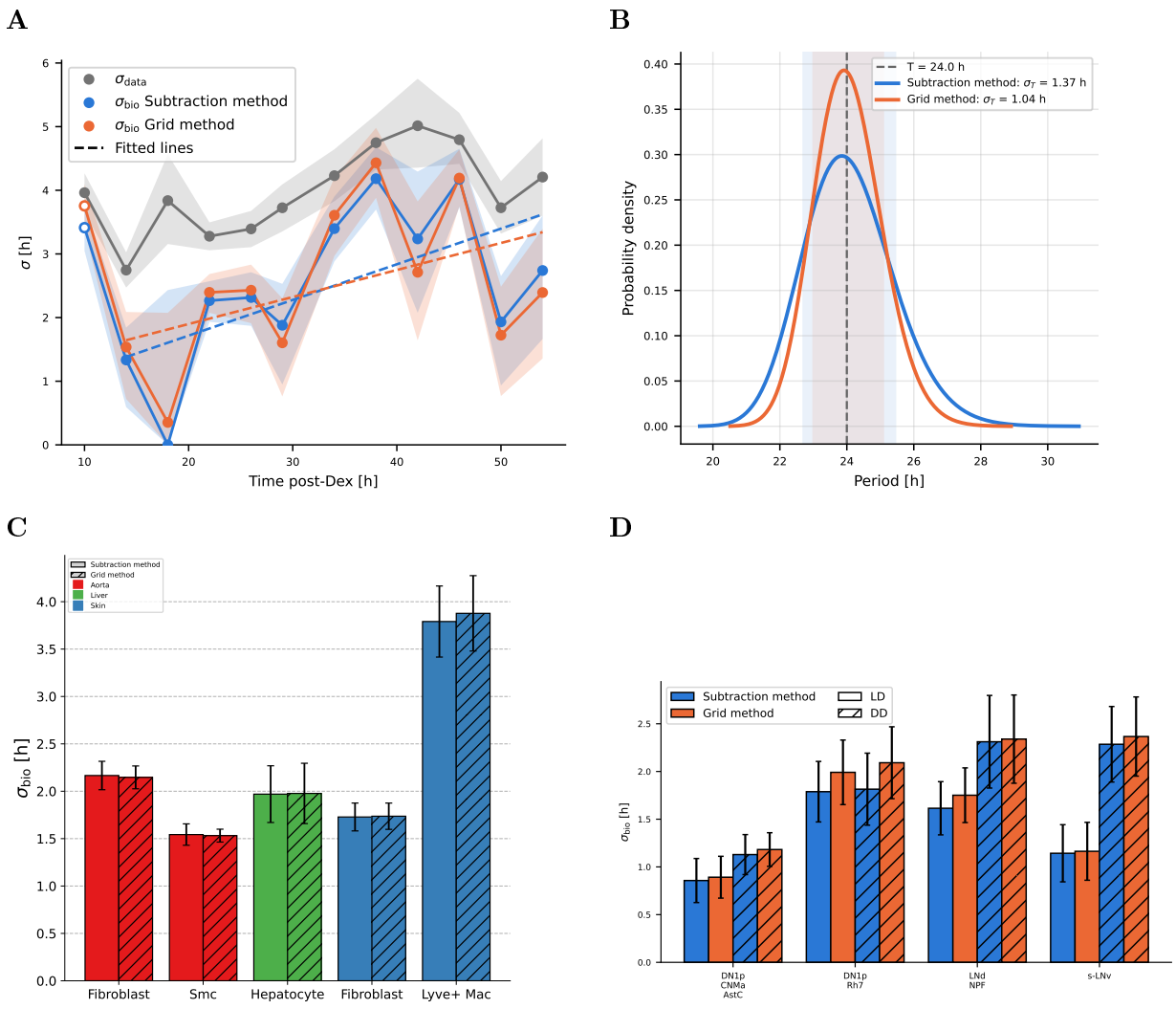


Figure Reb 2: **Subtraction method and grid method on the real data.** **(A)** SABER-FISH, as in Fig. 2G of the main text. Grey: σ_{data}. Blue: σ_{bio} with the subtraction method. Orange: σ_{bio} with the grid method. Bands: 95% intervals of a bootstrap over the cells (2000 draws, technical part held fixed). Dashed lines: lines fitted to the 11 time points after the first one (open markers, left out of the fit), slope not allowed to be negative. **(B)** Distribution of the period obtained from the slopes in A, as in Fig. 2H of the main text. Shaded: mean period plus or minus σ_T. **(C)** Mouse, *Extended-Set*, as in Fig. 3J of the main text. Single value of σ_{bio} over the samples of each cell type (Eq. 16 of the main text). Colors: organ. Plain bars: subtraction method. Hatched bars: grid method. Error bars: standard error. **(D)** *Drosophila*, as in Fig. 4F of the main text. Single value of σ_{bio} per cluster. Blue: subtraction method. Orange: grid method. Plain bars: light dark cycle (LD). Hatched bars: constant darkness (DD). Error bars: standard error.

R2.2

In the response R2.2, the authors go on to say that they "never define σ_{tech} as the within-term of a latent phase-cluster decomposition (an average over heterogeneous sub-populations)... so there is no averaging over sub-populations with differing variances to reconcile". Does this mean the author's procedure is not consistent with the Law of Total Variance, which must have an averaging procedure

across sub-populations? If so, when the authors say that "At the level of individual time points the additivity is only approximate", is the approximation coming partly from this departure from the Law of Total Variance? These points should be more carefully discussed in the Main Text and Methods, since the current version provides little clarity or discussion on this important issue.

Response. We thank the reviewer. Our first round sentence was wrong and we withdraw it. The reviewer's sub-populations are the cells of one sample grouped by their true phase, which is exactly the conditioning on θ of R2.1. With this conditioning the decomposition follows the law of total variance exactly (Eq. (1)). The within term T_b is the average, over these sub-populations, of their technical variance $f(\theta)$, so there is an averaging, as the reviewer said. We had answered at the wrong level, that of the groups S (one replicate at one ZT).

Where the approximation at single time points comes from.

The approximation does not come from a departure from the law of total variance, since the decomposition is exact. It comes in part from how the subtraction method estimates the within term: the subtraction method evaluates f at one phase instead of averaging f over the sub-populations, that is over p_b (A1 in R2.1). The bias (A2) adds to this approximation. This is what we meant in the first round by "partly because σ_{tech} is itself phase dependent", but we did not explain it. The paragraph "The average over groups" in R2.1 explains why averaging over groups cancels part of the error of the subtraction method and when the average over groups may be used. The grid method (R2.1, Appendix A) does the average over the sub-populations directly.

R2.3

The revised Methods state that Eq. 14 "becomes near-exact ($R^2 \approx 1$) only once variances are aggregated across populations that span the circadian cycle", and draw from this the requirement that "the data must cover most of the circadian cycle". In the response letter, the authors further comment that "σ_{bio} is a property of a population sampled across the cycle, not of an individual ZT". This is made explicit in Eq. 16 of the revised Main Text. This then raises the following important questions which I do not currently understand:

R2.3a

How can this requirement be reconciled with the analysis of the SABER-FISH dataset, where each ZT is analyzed separately to get σ_{bio} and σ_{tech} estimates at each time point? Given that this is the main dataset with direct experimental validation of the σ_{bio} estimates, the analysis of this data and the limitations should be discussed more carefully.

Response. We phrased the requirement badly, and we are sorry that the previous version was not clear. The method does not need an average around the clock. A single time point gives an estimate of σ_{bio}, and the SABER-FISH analysis uses the time points one by one. R2.1 shows the error of single groups next to the error of the average (Fig. Reb 1). The average over time points lowers the error, but only when we have good reason to think that σ_{bio} is the same at all time points.

R2.3b

The aggregation requirements of the method as well as all the simulations the authors have performed (Fig. Reb 3A and 3B [round 1]) seem to require one ground truth σ_{bio} for the entire population of cells across the different ZT time points. However, this requirement seems directly in conflict with the

SABER-FISH data, where σ_{bio} increases with time post Dexamethasone synchronization. Therefore, the authors need to give a clear justification for applying their method to this dataset. If this is only a very approximate and empirical application of the method, the authors should accordingly tone down their claims of discovering increasing desynchrony and using this dataset as a strong validation of their method.

Response. There is no conflict, as explained in R2.3a. The SABER-FISH analysis does not need the same σ_{bio} at all time points. We show this with simulations in which σ_{bio} rises over time, below in R2.3c.

R2.3c

All simulations in the manuscript appear to hold σ_{bio} to one fixed number across ZT time points, which is why the aggregation procedure seems to work via some cancellations. But if the σ_{bio} per ZT changes, as is the case with the SABER-FISH data, wouldn't this fundamentally create issues in recovering the right σ_{bio} estimates? Aggregation here would probably recover some sort of average of the individual σ_{bio}'s, right? Therefore in order to claim that scRitmo can extract meaningful increase of desynchrony over time, the authors should at least provide simulations where ground truth σ_{bio} increases across ZTs within a single simulation. This simulation should then be analyzed with scRitmo and the results benchmarked for accuracy.

Response. The reviewer is right that when σ_{bio} changes across time points, the single value over all of them (Eq. 16 of the main text) is only the average $\sqrt{\sum_t n_t \sigma_t^2 / \sum_t n_t}$, with n_t the number of cells at time point t, and this average hides the change.

We ran the simulation the reviewer asks for, in two forms. The first is a simulated copy of the SABER-FISH experiment (Fig. Reb 3). The second is an RNA-seq style experiment at three depths, with several shapes of σ_{bio} (Fig. Reb 4). In both simulations, a rise of σ_{bio} over time is recovered, with a slope about 10 to 15% too small, and a constant or cyclic σ_{bio} does not produce one. The estimates at single time points are less accurate than the slope, because of the error of the fitted model, and at 3k UMI per cell the RNA-seq style simulation is not reliable.

SABER-FISH COPY: SIMULATION.

We show both methods because they are two estimators of the same decomposition (R2.1) with different approximations. The subtraction method is the one in the paper. The grid method removes the approximations A1 and A2, so if the two agree, those approximations are not what drives the result. We built a copy of the experiment. The data are generated from the fitted model of the real data (template and the negative binomial dispersion of each of the 4 genes), with the 12 real time points and the real number of cells at each. The model uses the cell area where an RNA-seq fit uses the total counts, and we draw the areas of each time point from the real cells of that time point. The true phases of a time point follow a wrapped normal distribution around the phase of that time point, with a known σ_{bio}. We used two profiles. In the first, σ_{bio} rises linearly from 1.0 h at the first time point to 3.5 h at the last. In the second it is constant at 2.24 h, the average of the ramp over the 12 time points, and this profile checks what happens when there is no increase. The truth at each time point is the circular standard deviation of the true phases of its cells. Each of the 10 replicates of a profile is fitted again with the settings used for the real data (the mean phase of a time point is taken from the data) and then analyzed with the subtraction method and the grid method. We also give two oracles as a reference. Both know the true phase of every cell. One simulates each time point again with the fitted model, and the other with the model that generated the data. So the error of the fit is part of what we measure. The true spread of periods σ_T of

the ramp (1.40 h) is close to the real value with the subtraction method (1.37 h), so the test asks whether a value of this size is recovered, and not whether the real one is right.

SABER-FISH COPY: RESULT.

When the true σ_{bio} rises, the estimates rise with it (Fig. Reb 3A). As for the real data, we fitted a line to the estimated σ_{bio} (in hours) against time, over the 11 time points after the first one, and call the slope of this line s (hours per hour). The cells are given angular velocities $\omega \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_\omega, \sigma_\omega^2)$ with $\sigma_\omega = 2\pi s/(24\text{ h})$, and σ_T is the standard deviation of the periods $T = 2\pi/\omega$. For small s,

$$\sigma_T \approx 24\text{ h} \times s, \tag{3}$$

so an error of a given relative size in the slope is the same relative error in σ_T.

The true σ_T of the ramp is 1.40 h. The subtraction method gives 1.26 ± 0.17 h and the grid method 1.23 ± 0.19 h (mean and standard deviation over the 10 replicates). Both are too small, by 10% and 12% (Fig. Reb 3C). When the true σ_{bio} is constant at 2.24 h, the true σ_T is 0.18 h and not zero, because the spread of the true phases of the cells actually drawn varies a little between time points. The estimates are 0.29 ± 0.14 h (subtraction method) and 0.20 ± 0.21 h (grid method) (Fig. Reb 3D). In this fit the slope cannot be negative, as in the paper. A line fitted without that constraint differs from zero (t test, 5% level) in all 10 replicates of the ramp and in none of the 10 replicates of the constant profile, for both methods.

At single time points, the estimated σ_{bio} is too high on average, by about 0.5 h for the ramp and 0.4 h for the constant profile. The errors have bumps of up to 1.2 h that repeat across replicates (Fig. Reb 3A and Fig. Reb 3B). The oracle with the fitted model shows the same bumps and a similar offset (+0.37 and +0.27 h). The oracle with the model that generated the data does not (-0.04 and -0.08 h). Both oracles know the true phase of every cell and differ only in the model. So the error comes from the fitted gene parameters and not from the split of the variance. The grid method, which removes A1 and A2, does not remove these errors (the mean absolute errors of the two methods at single time points differ by 0.01 h).

SABER-FISH COPY: LIMITS.

(i) The true profile is a straight line and has no scatter between time points, while the real one may not. (ii) The simulated time points lie exactly on a 24 h clock. In the real fit the mean inferred phase of a time point is up to 1.7 h away from such a clock, and we did not simulate that. (iii) The generator is the fitted model, so the real data can differ from it in ways the simulation does not cover. (iv) There are 10 replicates, so the standard deviations above are rough. (v) The grid method uses one grid, which is a set of simulated cells at 24 evenly spaced true phases with the cell areas of all time points. The version with one grid per time point gives σ_T of 1.25 h (first time point left out) and 1.32 h (all 12 time points) for the ramp, which are close to the 1.23 h above.

RNA-SEQ STYLE: SIMULATION.

We simulated 15 clock genes and 12 time points of 500 cells, 4 h apart over two days as in the SABER-FISH experiment, at 3k, 10k or 30k UMI per cell (molecules counted over the whole transcriptome). The true σ_{bio} was constant (2.25 h), a ramp from 1.0 h to 3.5 h, or a cosine over the day from 0 to 3 h with its peak at ZT10 (peak of the aggregate circadian counts) or at ZT22 (near the trough). A control had a true σ_{bio} of 0. The cosines are the hard case, because the phase dependent error of the subtraction method (R2.1) does not average out when σ_{bio} depends on the phase. We retrained the model on each dataset and analyzed each dataset with the subtraction method and the grid method. Both methods estimate the same decomposition, and comparing

them checks whether the per group approximations of R2.1 matter when σ_{bio} changes. Numbers below are means over 5 replicates.

RNA-seq style: result.

At each time point (Fig. Reb 4A), the estimates follow the ramp and both cosines from 10k UMI upward, and are too high by up to about 0.8 h where the true σ_{bio} is near zero. At 3k the cosine peaking at ZT10 is lost, and the constant profile shows a 24 h pattern that is not in the truth. The single value over all time points (Fig. Reb 4B) is off by at most 0.07 h at 30k and 0.16 h at 10k for the four profiles with spread (single datasets at 10k by up to 0.7 h), and too high by 0.4 to 1.0 h at 3k.

For the ramp, the slope of a line fitted to the 12 estimates, divided by the true slope, is 0.90 (subtraction) and 0.93 (grid) at 30k, 0.85 and 0.91 at 10k, and 0.64 and 0.71 at 3k. The single values of the two methods lie within the error ranges given above, and the grid method does somewhat better on the slope of the ramp. On the constant and cosine profiles the fitted slope is at most 0.008 h per h in absolute value from 10k upward (0.05 for the ramp), and up to 0.014 at 3k. From 10k upward, a rise of σ_{bio} over time is therefore recovered, about 7 to 15% too small, and a constant or cyclic σ_{bio} does not produce one. At 3k UMI per cell this is not reliable.

RNA-seq style: limits.

With a true σ_{bio} of 0, the single value is too high at low depth: 1.4 to 1.7 h at 3k, 0.5 to 0.8 h at 10k, and -0.1 to 0.4 h at 30k. The grid method sets negative estimates to zero. At 10k and below, a small σ_{bio} is therefore not distinguished from none. In a one day design (ZT 0 to 22), where the ramp and the clock phase are the same axis, the slope ratios are lower (0.77 and 0.86 at 30k, 0.60 and 0.72 at 10k), the constant and cosine profiles give false slopes of up to 0.05 h per h at 10k (the true ramp slope is 0.11), and the grid method is 0.45 h off at 10k for the cosine peaking at ZT10. A rise of σ_{bio} within a single day should be interpreted with care.

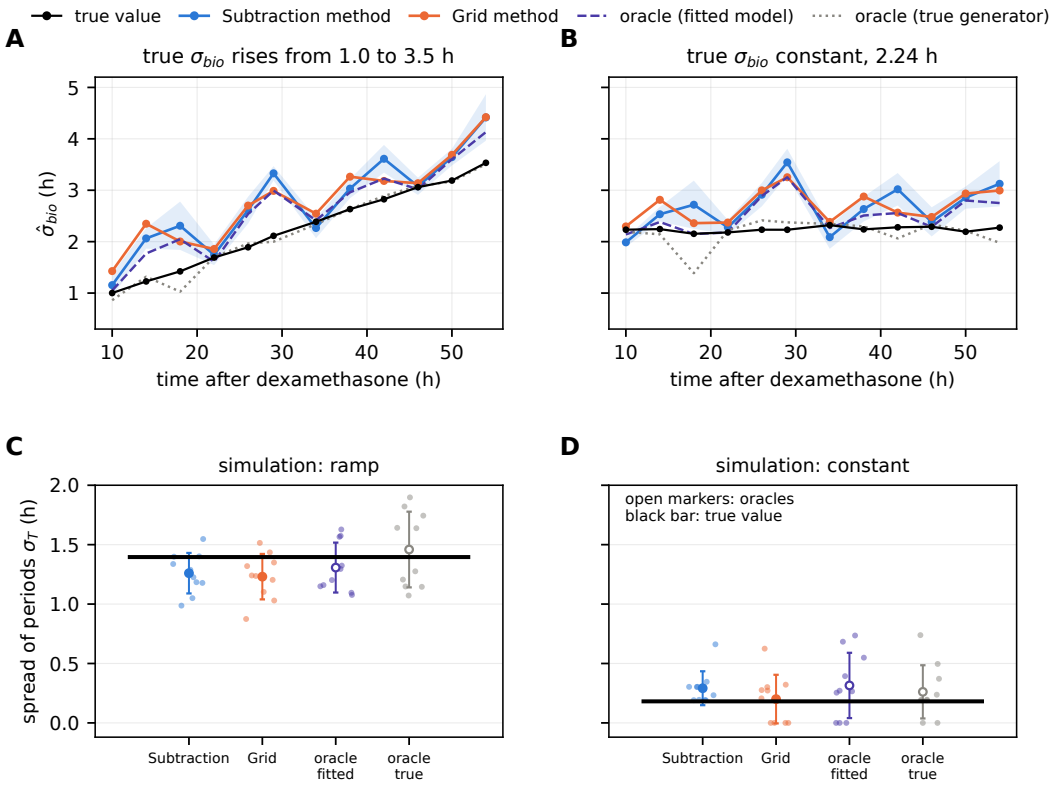


Figure Reb 3: **A simulated copy of the SABER-FISH experiment, with a known σ_{bio} at each time point. (A, B)** Simulation from the fitted model of the real data (4 genes), with the 12 time points and the numbers of cells of the real experiment and the cell areas of the real cells of each time point as library sizes. The model was fitted again on each of the 10 simulated datasets, and the estimates were made with the same settings as for the real data. Estimated σ_{bio} at each time point when the true value rises from 1.0 to 3.5 h (A) and when it is constant at 2.24 h (B). Black: true value, the circular standard deviation of the true phases of the simulated cells of that time point. Blue and orange: subtraction method and grid method, mean over the replicates. Blue band: standard deviation of the subtraction method over the replicates. Dashed purple: oracle with the fitted model, which knows the true phase of every cell and simulates the time point again with the fitted model. Dotted grey: the same oracle with the model that generated the data. The time point at 18 h has the fewest cells (116). **(C, D)** Spread of the single cell periods σ_T, obtained from the slope of a line fitted to the estimates of the 11 time points after the first one (the slope is not allowed to be negative), for the ramp (C) and the constant profile (D). Same colors as in A. The two oracles have open markers (fitted model in purple, true generator in grey). Black bar: σ_T from the line fitted to the true values, mean over the 10 replicates (it is not zero for the constant profile, because the true values vary a little around 2.24 h). Small dots: the 10 replicates. Large markers: mean and standard deviation over the replicates.

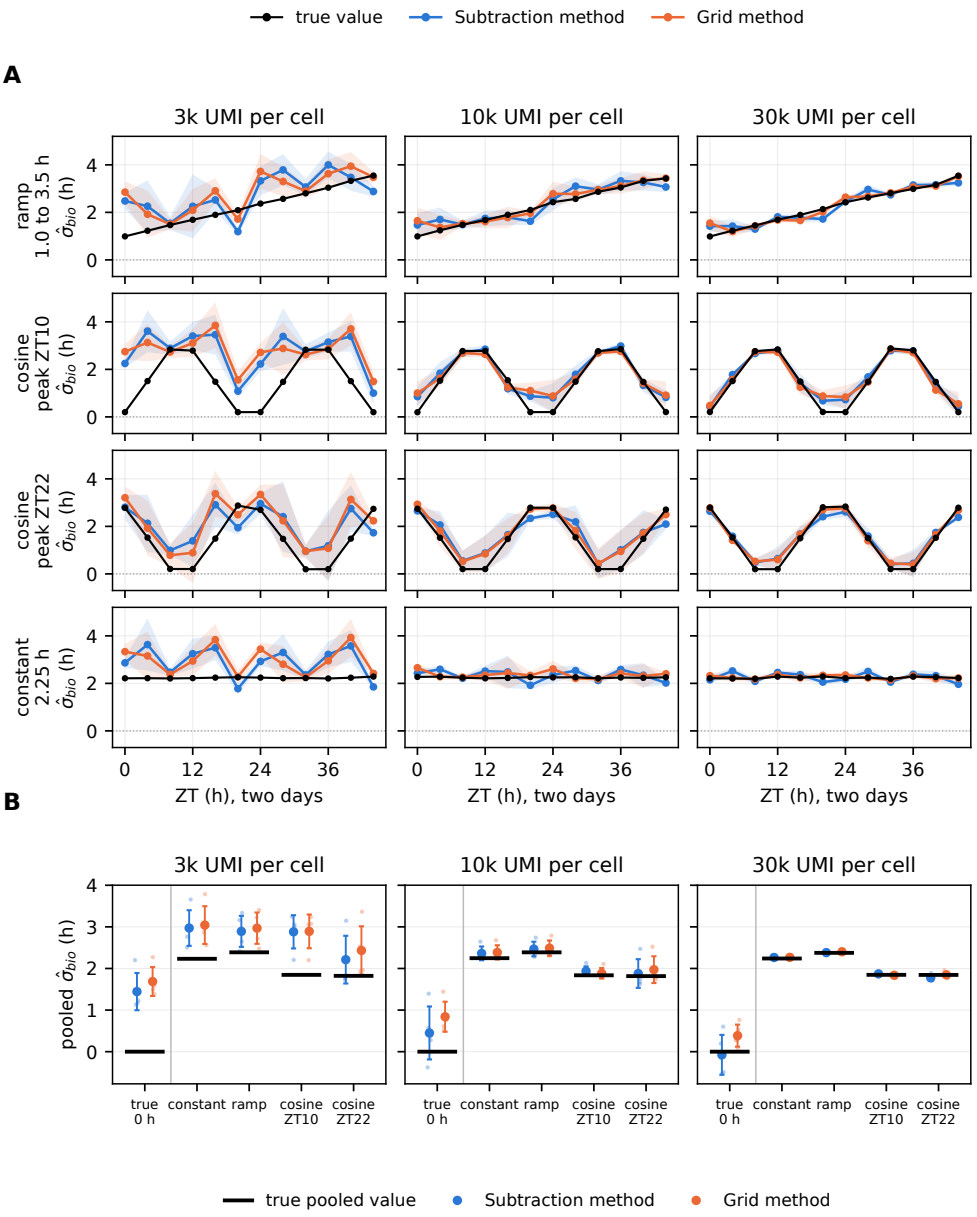


Figure Reb 4: **Simulations with a σ_{bio} that changes across time points.** 15 clock genes, 12 time points over two days, 500 cells per time point, 5 replicates per setting. Columns are the depths. **(A)** Estimated σ_{bio} at each time point for four true profiles (rows). Black: true value. Lines: mean over the replicates. Bands: standard deviation over the replicates. The true cosine is sampled every 4 h (0.2 to 2.8 h) and repeats on the second day. **(B)** The single value over all time points (Eq. 16 of the main text) for the same profiles (cosine ZT10 and ZT22 are the two cosines of A) and for a control with a true σ_{bio} of 0. Black bar: true value, the square root of the average of the true σ^2_{bio} weighted by cell number. Large markers: mean and standard deviation over the replicates. Small dots: the 5 replicates. Subtraction method and grid method are defined in the text and in the response to R2.1.

R2.3d

The equations for the aggregation and their corresponding description, both in the main text and response, are quite confusing because key quantities have been vaguely defined. What exactly do the words "condition" and "batch" mean here? What does the term σ_b refer to in Eq. 16 of the revised main text? None of these have been defined.

Response.

R2.4

The authors also comment that the aggregation procedure creates a requirement of sufficient ZT samples across 24 hours. In their simulations, they use 12 and 8 ZT samples, which is greater than the number of samples one would get from typical scRNA-seq datasets. For example, the Auerbach et al paper which the authors analyze, had only 4 samples spaced 6 hours apart. To better understand the limits of the aggregation procedure, the authors should demonstrate what happens in such limited datasets — would accurate estimates of a population σ_{bio} still be possible if there are just 4 samples?

Response. We simulated the case of the reviewer. The 4 time points are fixed at 0, 6, 12 and 18 h, and we changed the number of samples at each of them (1, 2 or 3, so 4, 8 or 12 samples in total), at 3k, 10k and 30k UMI per cell, with a true σ_{bio} of about 2.5 h (Fig. Reb 5). With 4 samples the single value of σ_{bio} (Eq. 16 of the main text) is still close to the truth. The mean error is -0.03 h at 10k and 30k UMI, with a standard deviation over the 10 simulated datasets of 0.10 h at 10k and 0.04 h at 30k. At 3k UMI the error is larger ($+0.12$ h with a standard deviation of 0.17 h). Going to 8 or 12 samples does not change the error much. So the number of samples matters little, as long as they span the whole cycle. The depth matters more. The grid method gives the same picture. The error stays within about 0.1 h at 10k UMI and above, including the small error left by the approximations A1 and A2 of R2.1.

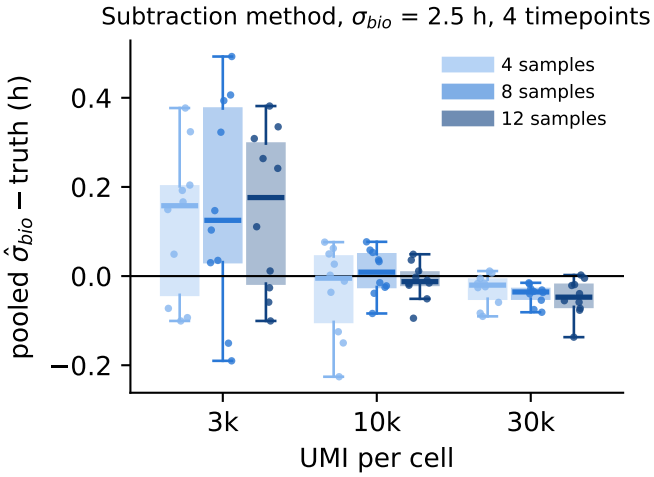


Figure Reb 5: **Single value of σ_{bio} with 4, 8 or 12 samples over 4 time points.** Simulation with 15 clock genes, 500 cells per sample, samples at 0, 6, 12 and 18 h (1, 2 or 3 samples per time point), and a true σ_{bio} of about 2.5 h at every time point. Horizontal axis: UMI per cell. Vertical axis: single value of σ_{bio} over all samples (Eq. 16 of the main text) with the subtraction method, minus the true value (circular standard deviation of the true phases). Shades of blue: number of samples. Dots: the 10 simulated datasets. Boxes: median and quartiles.

R2.5

In the application of the method to phase inference in asynchronized FLASH-seq data, I appreciate the new results presented and agree that they provide more evidence that biologically meaningful oscillations are being reconstructed. However, I'm still puzzled by the fact that the mRNA and protein oscillations look identical, and not phase shifted at all. The protein oscillation peak should be delayed by 2–4 hours as per a vast body of prior literature, which is not reflected in the results here. How does one interpret this? Does this suggest that in fact there are significant errors being made in phase assignment to the single cells? If so, I would recommend discussing this in the Main Text and also toning down the statement "The inferred phase accurately reconstructed the oscillation of both the endogenous (Rev-Erbα) mRNA level and the Rev-Erbα-Venus protein fluorescence", since the meaning of "accurately" cannot really be quantitatively established in this setting.

Response. We thank the reviewer. We were also surprised that the mRNA and protein curves look so similar, and we agree that "accurately" is too strong. We remove it. Below we measure the delay of the protein after its mRNA, show that errors in the inferred phase make the delay look shorter, and explain why a short delay is expected for this reporter.

The protein peaks about 0.7 h after its mRNA.

We fitted a 24 h cosine to each signal against the inferred phase and took the difference between the peaks. We compared the protein with the Venus mRNA, the transcript of the reporter itself. Like the protein, the Venus mRNA is not one of the clock genes used to infer the phase. The protein peaks 0.66 h after the Venus mRNA (95% interval 0.51 to 0.81 h, bootstrap over cells; Fig. Reb 6A). So there is a delay, but a short one.

The correlation between *Nr1d1* mRNA and protein across cells (Fig. 2A of the main text, $R^2 = 0.73$) gives a rough check that does not use the inferred phase. For two 24 h cosines 3 h apart (45 degrees), R^2 across unsynchronized cells is at most $\cos^2(45°) = 0.5$, and noise can only lower R^2. An R^2 of 0.73 therefore suggests a delay well below 3 h. The check is rough, because variation that mRNA and protein share for other reasons, such as cell size, also raises R^2.

Errors in the phase make the delay look shorter.

The reviewer is right that errors in the phase play a role. We simulated cells from the model fitted to these data. We added a protein signal that follows the *Nr1d1* profile with a known delay, plus noise, and a reporter mRNA with the same profile as *Nr1d1*. We sorted the cells into 4 bins of Venus level, as the real cells were sorted, and inferred the phase from the clock genes as for the real data. The measured delay was about two thirds of the true one (Fig. Reb 6B): a true delay of 2 h was measured as 1.3 h, and 4 h as 2.7 h. Against the true phase of the simulated cells, the delay came out right, so the shortening comes from the errors in the inferred phase. We corrected the real value with the straight line fitted to the simulated points (slope 0.67). The corrected delay is about 1 h (0.8 to 1.3 h), shorter than the 2 to 4 h the reviewer expects.

Why the delay is short for this reporter.

For a protein made in proportion to its mRNA and degraded at a constant rate, the delay grows with the half-life of the protein (Fig. Reb 6C).

$$\Delta = \arctan(\omega\, t_{1/2}/\ln 2)/\omega \tag{4}$$

Delays of 2 to 4 h correspond to half-lives of about 1.5 to 5 h. The Rev-erbα-Venus reporter is built to be unstable. It is Venus with a PEST sequence, which targets proteins for fast degradation,

fused to the first 116 amino acids of REV-ERBα [1]. Venus with this PEST sequence alone has a half-life of 1.8 h [2], which gives a delay of about 2.3 h. **REV-ERBα itself has a half-life of about 30 min**, which gives 0.7 h [3]. The signals that control this fast degradation lie in the part fused to the reporter: changing two serines among the first 116 amino acids of REV-ERBα makes REV-ERBα stable for more than 2 h [3]. Our corrected delay of about 1 h corresponds to a half-life of 0.6 to 0.9 h, between the two values. So the REV-ERBα part probably makes the reporter less stable than Venus with PEST alone, but we have not tested this. In mouse liver, REV-ERBα protein also peaks with relatively little delay after its mRNA [4].

Delays shorter than 1 h are visible in these data.

As a positive control, we used the unspliced reads, which come from the pre-mRNA. Pre-mRNA is made before mature mRNA, so it must peak earlier, and it is not used to infer the phase. The unspliced *Nr1d1* reads peak 0.8 h before the Venus mRNA (Fig. Reb 6A). The Venus mRNA peaks together with the spliced *Nr1d1* mRNA. The unspliced reads also come first for *Nr1d2*, *Dbp*, *Per2*, *Per3* and *Bmal1* (0.1 to 1.3 h), the other clock genes with a clear rhythm in both forms. Errors in the phase do not hide delays of 1 h or less. They only shorten them.

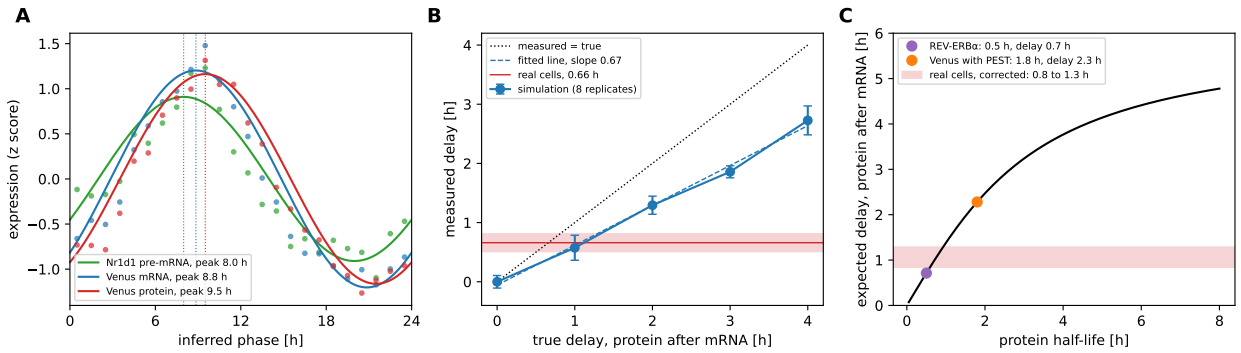


Figure Reb 6: **Delay between the Rev-erbα-Venus protein and its mRNA in the FLASH-seq cells. (A)** 695 cells. Unspliced *Nr1d1* reads (pre-mRNA, green), Venus mRNA (blue) and Venus protein fluorescence (red) against the inferred phase. All values on a log scale, then z scored across cells (mean 0, standard deviation 1). Dots: means in 1 h bins. Lines: fitted cosines. Dotted lines: peaks of the fits. **(B)** Simulated cells with a known delay of the protein after the mRNA (horizontal axis), analyzed like the real data. Vertical axis: delay measured against the inferred phase. Dots and bars: mean and standard deviation over 8 replicates of 696 cells (174 per bin of Venus level, as in the experiment). Dashed line: straight line fitted to the simulated points. Red line and band: the real cells (A), with the 95% interval of a bootstrap over the cells. **(C)** Delay of the protein peak after the mRNA peak for a 24 h rhythm, for a protein removed at a constant rate, as a function of its half-life. Dots: half-lives of REV-ERBα [3] and of Venus with the PEST sequence of the reporter [2]. Red band: 95% interval of the real delay (A) corrected with the fitted line in B.

R2.6

In the main text the authors say "Across all tissues, cells with higher posterior uncertainty σ_u showed larger phase errors than cells with lower σ_u (Fig. S3C, E, F), consistent with the per-cell correlation between σ_u and phase error". In the Discussion they say "The posterior uncertainty σ_u consistently predicts inference quality across simulations and diverse biological datasets, enabling

principled quality control without external time labels." However, in the light of the new quantification of correlations between σ_u and error (ranging from 0.08 to 0.35 in Fig. Reb 10A [round 1]), these statements seem quite disproportionate. Even the highest of these correlation values at 0.35 is weak at best, and it is also unclear whether any of these would pass statistical tests of significance. The authors should therefore report these magnitudes along with results from statistical tests in the Main text, and statements such as those above should be tempered accordingly.

Response. We thank the reviewer and agree. Correlations between 0.08 and 0.35 are weak, and our sentences in the Results and the Discussion claimed more than they support. We withdraw the claim that σ_u predicts inference quality or can be used for quality control. What the data show is that cells with higher σ_u have somewhat larger errors on average, so σ_u is a weak indicator for a single cell and not a basis to keep or drop cells.

Appendix A: the grid method

This appendix describes the grid method summarised in the response to R2.1. It uses the notation of R2.1: group b of n_b cells, true phase $\theta \sim p_b$, inferred phase $\hat{\theta}$, $\rho(\theta) = \mathbb{E}[e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{\theta}} \mid \theta] = r(\theta)\, e^{\mathrm{i}m(\theta)}$, and the approximations A1 and A2 of the subtraction method. In scRitmo it is `estimate_phase_desynchrony(sigma_tech_method="deconvolution", deconv_form="vector")`.

Starting point.

Instead of correcting the approximations A1 and A2 one by one, we start from the exact identity of R2.1, Eq. (2). Its left side is what the data give (estimated by the mean $\bar{z}_b$ of $e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{\theta}_c}$ over the cells, with $\bar{R}_b = |\bar{z}_b|$). On the right, $\rho(\theta)$ is the technical part, which depends only on the model and the library sizes, and p_b is the biological part, whose width is $\sigma_{\mathrm{bio},b}$. The identity needs no expansion, and no assumption that r is constant or $m(\theta) = \theta$.

Step 1, measure ρ on a grid.

At each of $N = 24$ phases $\phi_k = 2\pi(k-1)/N$ (1 h apart) we simulate Twin cells (1000 per run, 5 runs pooled, so $M = 5000$), infer their phases and take the mean unit vector $\hat{\rho}_k = \frac{1}{M}\sum e^{\mathrm{i}\hat{\theta}}$ over the M cells at ϕ_k. This is a plain mean, so $\mathbb{E}[\hat{\rho}_k] = \rho(\phi_k)$. We keep the complex value, because its direction holds the bias.

Step 2, Fourier series.

Since ρ is periodic,

$$\rho(\theta) = \sum_{j=-J}^{J} c_j\, e^{\mathrm{i}j\theta}, \qquad c_j = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{k=1}^{N} \hat{\rho}_k\, e^{-\mathrm{i}j\phi_k}, \qquad J = \lfloor N/2 \rfloor, \tag{5}$$

where the term at $|j| = N/2$ is split in two halves, so that the series passes through every grid point.

Step 3, average over the biological distribution.

We assume p_b is a wrapped normal with center μ_b and width σ in radians, where σ is the trial value of $\sigma_{\mathrm{bio},b}$. For harmonic j (period $24/j$ h),

$$\mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim p_b}\left[e^{\mathrm{i}j\theta}\right] = \kappa_j(\sigma)\, e^{\mathrm{i}j\mu_b}, \qquad \kappa_j(\sigma) = e^{-j^2\sigma^2/2}. \tag{6}$$

The factor κ_j lies between 0 and 1. A distribution that is wide compared with the period covers both the peak and the trough of the harmonic, and the average shrinks toward zero. Putting Eq. (5) into the right side of Eq. (2) gives the expected mean vector of a group,

$$\bar{\rho}_b(\sigma) = \mathbb{E}_{\theta\sim p_b}\left[\rho(\theta)\right] = \sum_{j=-J}^{J} c_j\, \kappa_{|j|}(\sigma)\, e^{\mathrm{i}j\mu_b}. \tag{7}$$

The grid gives all the c_j, so this is a known function of σ. Under the conditions where Eq. 14 is exact (r constant, $m(\theta) = \theta$, and many cells), it reduces to Eq. 14.

Step 4, one equation with one unknown.

For independent cells, $\mathbb{E}[\bar{R}_b^2] = |\bar{\rho}_b|^2 + (1 - |\bar{\rho}_b|^2)/n_b$, where the second term comes from the n_b products of a cell with itself. The estimate $\hat{\sigma}_{\mathrm{bio},b}$ is the value of σ that solves

$$|\bar{\rho}_b(\sigma)|^2 + \frac{1 - |\bar{\rho}_b(\sigma)|^2}{n_b} = \bar{R}_b^2. \tag{8}$$

Here $\bar{R}_b$ and n_b come from the data, the c_j from the grid, and μ_b is the ZT of the group in the phase frame of the fitted model, so only σ is unknown. We search σ over $[0, \pi]$ and accept a root only if it is unique. If the data are tighter than the prediction at $\sigma = 0$ we set the estimate to zero. If no unique root exists, the group has no estimate. The estimand is $\sigma_{\text{bio},b}$, the spread of θ, and not B_b.

The group phase when the ZT is not known.

The steps above need μ_b. When the external time does not give the clock phase of the cells, as in the SABER-FISH data (time after dexamethasone), μ_b has to come from the data. The circular mean of the inferred phases is not a good choice, because the bias pulls it toward the trough of the aggregate circadian counts. The grid already measures this pull: $m(\theta) = \arg \rho(\theta)$ is the mean direction of the inferred phases of a synchronized group at true phase θ. We therefore take as μ_b the phase whose synchronized group has the observed mean direction, that is the solution of $\arg \rho(\mu) = \arg \bar{z}_b$ (the root closest to $\arg \bar{z}_b$). This undoes the shift of the mean by the bias. Where $m(\theta)$ is too flat to be inverted, which can happen at very low depth, we keep the circular mean. We also tried to solve for μ_b and σ together, matching both the direction and the length of $\bar{\rho}_b(\sigma)$ to $\bar{z}_b$, and it was not better.

We tested this on the simulation of R2.1, with 6 groups of 500 cells and 3 replicates, and one fit and one grid shared by all variants. Compared with the circular mean, the corrected phase lowers the mean absolute error of $\hat{\sigma}_{\text{bio},b}$ at 3k UMI per cell from 0.9 to 1.2 h to 0.4 to 0.8 h. This is the same as with the known ZT (0.3 to 0.8 h). At 10k it is between 0.05 h worse and 0.08 h better than with the known ZT, and at 30k the three choices of μ_b differ by 0.03 h or less. In scRitmo this is the option `debias_mean=True`, together with `use_circular_mean=True`.

What is removed.

A1 disappears because Eq. (7) averages ρ over the whole distribution p_b. A2 disappears because ρ contains the direction $m(\theta)$, so the bias is inside the prediction. The circular correction disappears because Eq. (8) compares mean vectors and does not add variances, and the finite n_b term is included. What remains is an offset between the phase origin of the fitted model and ZT 0 (0.2 to 0.55 h in our simulation), which affects both methods.

One σ_{bio} shared by all groups.

When all groups have the same σ_{bio}, Eq. 16 of the main text averages the solutions of Eq. (8) over the groups. We can instead average the equations and solve once. The step follows from the law of total expectation, applied twice. Inside group b, conditioning on θ gives Eq. (2), and from it $\mathbb{E}[\bar{R}_b^2] = L_b(\sigma_{\text{bio}})$, with $L_b(\sigma) = |\bar{\rho}_b(\sigma)|^2 + (1 - |\bar{\rho}_b(\sigma)|^2)/n_b$ the left side of Eq. (8). Across groups, take a cell at random, so that its group b has probability $w_b = n_b / \sum_{b'} n_{b'}$, and condition on b. Then $\mathbb{E}_b\big[\mathbb{E}[\bar{R}_b^2 \mid b]\big] = \sum_b w_b \, L_b(\sigma_{\text{bio}})$, which is again exact. Matching it to the data gives one equation in σ,

$$\sum_b n_b \, \bar{R}_b^2 = \sum_b n_b \, L_b(\sigma), \tag{9}$$

which we solve as Eq. (8), with an estimate of zero when the data of all groups together are tighter than the prediction at $\sigma = 0$. Each L_b keeps its own μ_b, so the technical part still changes from group to group. Only σ is shared. Two things improve over Eq. 16 of the main text. The noise of the groups cancels before the solve, which is not linear in $\bar{R}_b^2$. And the estimate is set to zero at most once per data set, not once per group, which is what makes Eq. 16 of the main text too large when the true σ_{bio} is small.

We tested it on the simulation of R2.1, also with 1 or 2 of the 6 groups removed, and it gives

results similar to Eq. 16 of the main text with the grid method. When $\sigma_{\mathrm{bio},b}$ changes across groups, Eq. (9) gives approximately the average of $\sigma^2_{\mathrm{bio},b}$ weighted by $n_b|\bar{\rho}_b|^2$ and not by n_b, so there we keep the estimates per group, as for SABER-FISH. In scRitmo it is `solve_vector_shared`.

Assumptions that remain.

The wrapped normal shape of p_b; a fitted model close to the data generating process; one library size distribution shared by all groups (otherwise we build one grid per group); independent cells; and a grid large enough that its own sampling noise is small next to that of the data. The case where $\sigma_{\mathrm{bio},b}$ changes from group to group, as in the SABER-FISH data, is tested in R2.3b and R2.3c.

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